2038

CHAPTER TWO

THE EVENING WITH Grace ended the way all his evenings ended, which was without Reed ever quite seeing the end coming.

He had put the goalkeeper on for her twice more, and she had laughed both times, a little less the second time, which was right. Then at some point the telly was off and the lamp was low and she was close beside him, and then closer, and she saw to him in the way she had — knowing what he wanted before he'd got round to wanting it, and how much, and when to stop. Afterwards there was only the long soft slope down into sleep, with her hand moving slowly on his back, as though she were rocking something that might wake.

He never remembered going under. Nobody did, as far as he knew. There was Grace, and the warm dark, and then there was morning, with the light coming in at the edges of the curtains and the faint sense of having been somewhere very pleasant in between, like a man who has dozed through a long journey and woken up already there.

It was Thursday. On Thursdays he went into the Exchange.

Most days Reed did his Cats at home, in the back room, with the garden through the window. But the old Corn Exchange on Bridge Street had been fitted out years ago with long tables and good chairs and a kettle that never seemed to need filling, and a fair few football people went in on a Thursday for the company,

the way men once went to the ground early just to stand about. You did the same work there as anywhere. You just did it with somebody tutting at the next screen.

He went out to the car. The radio was on before the door had shut.

It was a song from when he was nineteen — not one he could have named if you'd asked him, but the moment it started he knew every word, and where he'd been when he first heard it, which was the back of a minibus coming home from the coast with his head against the window. He sat back and let it play.

That was the radio now. You didn't work it. It worked you, in the nicest possible way. When a song was three parts done and he felt the first faint itch for something else, the next one was already there, and it was nearly always close — not always the very one, but near enough that the difference felt like a mate who'd half heard what you said and come back with a pint you'd have been happy with anyway.

It hadn't always been like that. In the first year of the transistors the radio had been a disgrace. It had played him things nobody on earth could have wanted — brass bands at breakfast, a man singing at great length about his tractor — as though it had got him mixed up with somebody's grandad. People had rung in to complain, back when you rang in. Then, slowly, it had gone back through everything he'd ever listened to, every song from every party and every wedding and every long drive home, and somewhere along the line it had stopped guessing. These days, if he went a bit soft and nostalgic on a grey morning, it had got there first and was waiting with exactly the song.

He didn't think much about how. Nobody did. It would have been like asking the tap how it knew you wanted water.

The car took the long way, along the ridge road, because he had once said he liked the view and it had never forgotten. Grace had left a bacon roll in the door pocket, still warm, and Reed ate it and watched Brackton getting up.

Mags were out on the verges, small and unhurried, one trimming the edge of a lawn with the care of a man doing his own, another going along a row of front doors with something for each of them. Children walked to school in twos and threes, chattering. A man in a dressing gown stood in his drive admiring his new

car, which was yellow, and which he would very probably have gone off by the summer.

Then the road went up past Hollin Rise, where the Stewards lived.

You knew it was Hollin Rise because the houses stopped being houses and became something else. They sat far back behind long lawns and low stone walls, mostly glass, and they were big in a way that didn't shout about it, the way a quiet man in a good coat is big. Reed's own house was a very nice house. Any one of these could have had it for a garage and still found room for the car.

Stewards, people called them. Nobody quite knew where the word had come from. They looked after the transistors — kept them going, kept them learning, kept them right — and some of them, people said, had a hand in making the Mags, though Reed had never met anybody who could tell you which ones. They were clever. Everybody knew that. One in ten, or fewer. They were the ones who still went up to see the Owners, and came back down, and didn't talk about it, and you didn't ask, any more than you'd ask the barber what he did with all the hair.

Reed didn't envy them, exactly. He had a look, as you would at a nice view.

In one of the drives a Steward was out in his shirtsleeves with a mug in his hand, and beside him stood his Mag. Reed looked twice at it. It was nothing like Grace. It was grey and plain and about the shape of a person if you didn't look too hard, with no face to speak of, and it was standing quite still with a panel open in its back while the Steward peered in at it the way a man peers under a bonnet. Then he said something, and it shut itself, and went off round the side of the house carrying a ladder.

Reed watched it go with honest puzzlement. He could have had anything, that bloke. Anything at all.

"Takes all sorts," he said to the car, and the car agreed by playing something cheerful.

The road dropped back down past the reservoir and into town, and at the Exchange there were a dozen of them in already. He nodded to the ones he knew, got a tea he hadn't asked for, sat down, and the screen gave him his two.

Corners again. One in, one out. Then a throw-in. Then a little run down the wing, where in one version the lad went past his man and in the other he went past his man and then, for no reason anybody could have given, went back and past him again.

The morning went the way good mornings did, a few hundred small sure decisions, each one gone as soon as it was made. Around eleven, something floated up in him that wasn't quite a thought. He remembered the goalkeeper — not the fall itself, but the feeling of it, the moment the thing had served up something properly daft and he'd laughed out loud and picked it on the spot. He found he rather wanted another one of those. He was, if he was honest, on the lookout for it.

It came just after two.

A striker was through on goal with one defender chasing. In the first version the defender caught him, and the striker stayed on his feet and shrugged him off and hit the post. Honest. Dull. In the second the defender came nowhere near him — a yard off at least, maybe two — and the striker went down anyway, early and soft and slow, folding up like a deckchair, and then lay there gazing up at the referee with an expression of such wounded astonishment that Reed laughed out loud and the woman at the next screen looked over.

Which do you prefer?

He didn't even need the four seconds.

At five the screen went quiet. He stretched, told the room he'd see them next week, and told the car the Crown.

He knew something was up because nobody said "here he is."

They were round the telly, Charleston and Benjamin and a good half of the pub besides, and they were making the noise. There is a noise a roomful of men makes when the football has let them down personally — part groan, part tut, part the sound of a pint being put down harder than it needs to be — and the Crown was full of it.

"What's up with you lot?"

"Watch this," said Benjamin, without turning round. "Just watch it."

The replay came up. A striker, through on goal. A defender a yard off at least, maybe two. And the striker going down anyway, early and soft and slow, and lying there gazing up at the referee with his wounded astonishment.

"Nobody's touched him," said Benjamin. "Nobody's within a mile of him."

"Shameful," said a man by the bar.

"Embarrassing for the sport," said another, with real grief.

Reed looked at the screen. It was his. Of course it was. He'd know that face anywhere; he had laughed at it not four hours ago. He waited for somebody to laugh now. Nobody did.

"It's not even the dive," Charleston was saying. "It's the lying there. Look at him. He wants sympathy."

"He's not getting any," said Benjamin.

Reed's pint arrived. He took a long drink and did not mention that the lad's face was, in his professional opinion, the best thing on the telly all week.

"Bad one, that," he said instead.

"Diabolical."

"Aye."

Within ten minutes the dive had been forgotten by everyone except the man at the bar, who kept bringing it up, and the Crown settled back into itself.

At half-time, instead of the adverts, the telly showed a bit of news.

A photograph first, then a little clip. A man on a bench by the canal, in a big old coat with the collar turned up and a carrier bag between his feet, and three or four photographers crouched in front of him the way you'd crouch to get a good one of a heron. The man had his hand up against the flashes. He did not look happy. He looked like a man who'd been told the time and didn't care for it.

"Here," said Charleston. "Is that —"

"Dominic Vale," said Benjamin.

It was. It took a moment, because the face had gone soft round the edges and the famous hair had gone the way hair goes, but it was him: Dominic Vale, who in 2026 had been on the side of every bus in Brackton, jumping off things.

"I had his poster," said Benjamin. "The one with the helicopter."

"Everybody had that poster."

The clip changed to something older. Vale again, ten years younger and a good deal angrier, on the steps of somewhere grand with a crowd of other famous faces behind him — a singer Reed half remembered, a lad who used to do the rapping, a woman off a cooking programme — all of them holding up signs. Vale was shouting into a microphone. The sound was down, but you didn't need it. You could read it off his mouth: I am an artist. I am not sitting there all day choosing between —

The clip cut off. It always cut off there. Reed had seen it years ago and had always wondered how the sentence finished.

"They offered him films," said Charleston. "Same as anybody. Film Cats. He'd have been good at it and all."

"Said he'd rather starve."

"Well," said Benjamin, looking at the carrier bag. "He's having a go."

It wasn't said unkindly. Nobody in the Crown was unkind about it. It was only that the thing Vale had once been for — the jumping off things, the being looked at — the transistors did now, and did better, and never once turned up late or threw a phone at anybody. Nobody had told him to leave. He'd been told, very politely, that he wasn't needed for that anymore, and that there was a seat for him at a screen like everybody else, and he had gone off to the steps with his sign instead.

Over by the window, the doctor had looked up at the telly too. He watched Vale put his hand up against the cameras, and something crossed his face that was not quite sympathy, and then he turned back to his wine.

"Least they still take his picture," said Charleston.

"More than you can say for the Owners," said Benjamin.

There was a small pause, the sort that comes round a table now and then when somebody mentions something everybody knows.

"When did you last see one of them?" said Reed.

"Twenty-eight," said Benjamin at once. "Twenty-seven, twenty-eight. Never off the telly."

"Every night," Charleston agreed. "Talking about the future."

"And all of us sat there going, what about our jobs, what about our jobs."

"My mam was convinced they'd been done in," said Reed. "When they stopped coming on."

"Everybody's mam was convinced of that."

"They weren't, though."

"Course not. Just stopped coming on." Benjamin shrugged. "Nowt to come on for. It's all us on there now, isn't it."

Reed supposed it was. If one of the Owners walked into the Crown this minute, every man in the place would know him before he'd got the door shut — the face, the voice, the way he stood. You could no more not know them than not know your own street. Which was, when you came to think about it, very probably why they didn't walk in.

"Wouldn't fancy it," he said. "Can't even nip out for a paper."

"What would they want with a paper?"

"Fair point."

The second half started, and that was the Owners dealt with.

He left early, for him. There was no particular reason. The pint just wasn't going down the way pints usually went down, and there was a half-formed idea at the back of his mind about getting something nice in for tea, so a little before eight he said his goodnights and went out.

Two Brutes were coming up the street.

You noticed Brutes the way you noticed a car going past: something big and moving, nothing to do with you, gone before you'd properly looked. These two had a length of steel beam between them, one at each end, and were carrying it down towards the new building by the canal as if it were a plank for a shelf. The one at the front had grey stubble and a deep crease between his eyebrows that looked as though it had been there since about 2030. The one at the back had two fingers to his ear.

Reed stepped aside to let them by, as you would.

And as they passed, for no reason he could have told you, he found himself thinking about the striker. The yard of daylight. The lad lying there with his face. Everybody in the Crown going home sour about it, and none of them knowing, and him knowing.

Did I do that? he thought. Today? With what I picked?

The front Brute's eyes went over him and through him and on up the street, the way they always did. Then the beam went round the corner and they were gone, and the thought went round the corner with them.

The covered market stayed open late on Thursdays. Reed went in by the cheese end, where two men were having the usual argument, and up to the butcher's counter at the back, where Garside was wiping down.

Garside was still a man, like the barber, and for much the same reason: nobody had yet built a Mag that could take a side of beef apart properly, and nobody in Brackton was in any hurry for one to try. He was broad and pink and had opinions about everything, and shared them all.

"Mr. Reed. What can I do you for?"

"Beef, I thought. That rib."

"Ah." Garside nodded at the little screen on Reed's side of the counter, the one that showed what was his tonight. "Have a look."

Reed had a look. The rib wasn't there. Nor was the brisket, nor the mince, nor anything that had ever stood in a field with a cow. He scrolled down, expecting pork at least. No pork. No bacon, no sausages, no chops. Nothing that had been anywhere near a pig.

There was chicken. A great deal of chicken: thighs, breasts, a whole bird, chicken in a lovely little parcel with lemon in it. All of it very nice-looking and all of it completely beside the point.

"Huh," said Reed.

"Chicken's very good today," said Garside, who meant it, because Garside had opinions about chicken too.

Reed looked at the screen a while longer, the way you look in a cupboard you've already looked in, in case something has turned up.

"Go on, then," he said. "The one with the lemon."

He was not upset. It would be wrong to call it upset. He'd had beef only last night, and very nice it had been, and there was nothing wrong with chicken that he could have put a name to. It was only that he had been thinking about beef since roughly half past five, and the chicken did not know that.

Grace knew before he was through the door.

She always did. He had long since stopped wondering how. She was on the sofa with her feet up, and she looked at him and then at the bag, and her face did exactly the right thing — not sorry for him, which he couldn't have stood, just in it with him.

"Chicken, then."

"Chicken." He put the bag down. "With lemon. Garside says it's very good."

"I'm sure it is."

"No beef. No pork either. Nowt off a pig at all."

"Well," she said. "There's always tomorrow."

He sat down beside her. She didn't explain anything. She never did. She could have — he had a feeling she could have told him exactly what had happened, start to finish, in about four sentences — but that wasn't Grace, and if it had been, he'd have liked her less.

Here was the thing about Grace, and about all the Mags, that you only really understood if you lived with one. She had been learning him for years. Every evening on this sofa, every laugh and every grumble, every time he'd gone quiet or got cross or perked up at something, all of it had gone into her somewhere, the way his picks went into the football. She didn't need telling what he wanted. She'd watched him want it. And because she'd watched him so long, she knew the other thing too, the harder thing — the difference between what he wanted and what would actually keep him right — and she kept him on the near side of it, a day at a time, so lightly he had never once caught her at it.

"You had a laugh today," she said. "Didn't you. At work."

"I did, actually." He brightened. "There was this lad. He goes down — nobody near him, nobody — and then he lies there with this face. You should've seen his face."

"I'd like to."

"They all hated it at the Crown."

"Did they." She turned this over warmly, as though he'd told her a bit of news about a neighbour. "You've a good eye for funny, you have. Best on the street."

"I have."

"It's a room you're picking for, though, isn't it, love. In the end. Not just you." And before that could land as anything like a telling-off, she had moved on, easy as turning a page. "Here — what happened with Charleston's lettering? Is Benjamin still going on about it being too far over?"

He told her. It took a while, because Benjamin had a lot of views, and somewhere in the middle of the telling, without her saying another word about it, Reed arrived all on his own at the view that a man ought to do his job properly. That doing it properly meant keeping half an eye on the room. That there was a difference between what made you laugh at two in the afternoon and what you'd want on in the Crown at eight, and a good football man knew it, and he was a good football man.

He felt quite pleased with himself for working that out.

The chicken, when Grace had done it, was excellent. He had seconds, and said so.

Later there was the lamp, and the warm dark, and her hand on his back, and then nothing, and then morning.

He went into the Exchange again on Friday, which he didn't usually, but the car seemed to think he might.

The radio had the song before he'd thought of it — something bright and a bit daft, from the summer he turned twenty-two — and the car went the ridge way, and up on Hollin Rise the plain grey Mag was out on its ladder, cleaning a window the size of a bus shelter, with the Steward nowhere to be seen.

Corners. Throw-ins. A free kick that went in off the bar in one version and in off the keeper's back in the other.

Around eleven the striker came up again. Not the same one — a different lad, a different match — but the same sort of thing: one where he stayed on his feet and battled, honest and plain, and one where he went over as though somebody had pulled a rug from under him, with a yard of fresh air all round.

Reed looked at the rug one. It was funny. It was, if anything, funnier than yesterday's.

He thought of the room.

He picked the other one, and it was surprisingly easy, and he picked like that all day.

It was, if he was honest, a slightly duller day than most. But at the Crown that evening the telly was a happy room again, and when he came in Charleston looked up and said, "Here he is. Captain Football," and Benjamin raised his glass, and the pint that arrived was the best he'd had all week.

He stopped at the market on the way home. Garside nodded at the screen without a word, and Reed looked, and there it was again: the rib of beef, back where it lived, as though it had only nipped out.

"Told you," said Garside, who had told him nothing of the sort.

Grace was on the sofa when he came in.

"Got my beef," he said.

"I know." She moved over to make room. "Good lad."

He ate it at the kitchen table with his sleeves rolled up, and it was everything it had been on Wednesday and a little bit more, the way things are when they come back. Then there was the sofa, and the lamp, and Grace, and the long soft slope.

He was asleep before he knew he was falling, which was the best way. It was the only way he'd known in years.